

Health Service Performance and Political Trust in Nigeria: An Analysis of Afrobarometer Round 9 Data

Objective

This analysis examines whether Nigerian citizens' perceptions of government performance in health-service delivery are associated with their trust in political institutions, specifically the presidency. As a medical student with an interest in governance and public policy, I undertook this self-directed project to explore the intersection of health systems and democratic accountability using nationally representative survey data.

Data and Method

The analysis uses data from the Afrobarometer Round 9 Nigeria Survey (Afrobarometer, 2023), a nationally representative face-to-face survey of 1,600 respondents across Nigeria. Two key variables were analyzed: Q46g ("How well or badly would you say the current government is handling improving basic health services?") and Q37a ("How much do you trust the president?"). Descriptive frequencies and a cross-tabulation with a Pearson Chi-Square test were conducted using IBM SPSS Statistics.

Findings

Descriptive results show that a majority of respondents rate government performance on health services negatively: 38.7% said the government is handling health service improvement "very badly" and 29.2% said "fairly badly," meaning 67.9% of respondents hold a negative view of health-service delivery. Trust in the presidency was similarly low, with 45.4% reporting they trust the president "not at all."

A cross-tabulation revealed a clear and statistically significant relationship between the two variables. Among respondents who rated health-service handling as "very badly," 66.1% also reported no trust in the president at all, compared to just 29.0% among those who rated it "fairly well." Conversely, trust "a lot" in the president rose from 4.4% (among those rating health handling "very badly") to 15.3% (among those rating it "fairly well"). This relationship was highly statistically significant (Pearson $\chi^2(20) = 279.02$, $p < .001$, $N = 1,604$), indicating the pattern is very unlikely to be due to chance.

Interpretation

These findings suggest that citizens' evaluations of health-service delivery may function as a visible and tangible proxy through which they judge the broader legitimacy and performance of government. Because healthcare is a service most citizens interact with directly, perceptions of its quality may carry particular weight in shaping political trust — more so than abstract evaluations of governance. This has implications for public policy and governance actors: improving frontline service delivery, such as health care, may be an effective pathway to rebuilding institutional trust.

Limitation

Some response categories, particularly "very well" ($n=30$), had small sample sizes, and 40% of cells in the cross-tabulation had expected counts below 5. This does not invalidate the overall

significant result given the large total sample size, but findings within smaller categories should be interpreted with caution.

References

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